

A Mindful Way to Ride Out Cravings Without Acting On Them

Urge Surfing is a mindfulness-based technique that helps you observe and ride out cravings or impulses without giving in to them. Rather than fighting the urge or avoiding it, you learn to watch it rise, peak, and fade like a wave.

For example, you are trying to cut down on checking Instagram, especially during work hours. One afternoon, you feel a strong urge to open the app when you hear a notification ping.

Instead of giving in, you pause and remind yourself: "This is just an urge. It will pass."

You sit back, close your eyes for a moment, and focus on your breathing, noticing how the urge feels in your body (a bit of restlessness in your hands, tension in your chest).

You don't try to fight the urge or distract yourself, instead you simply observe it like a wave, rising and eventually falling. After a few minutes, the urge feels less intense, and you are able to return to your work without opening the app.

It's especially helpful for managing:

- Internet or phone overuse.
- Social media scrolling.
- Gaming urges.

Why It Works

Urges feel intense, but they are temporary. Most last 5—30 minutes. When you stop fueling them with action or resistance, they naturally fade. By surfing the wave, you build control and awareness instead of acting on autopilot.

Steps for Urge Surfing

1. Pause and Notice

- Acknowledge: "I'm feeling an urge."
- Remind yourself: "I don't need to act on it."

2. Turn Inward

- Shift attention to your body.
- Where do you feel the urge? (e.g., tension in chest, restlessness in fingers).
- Describe the sensations like a curious observer.

3. Breathe Through It

- Focus on your breath.
- Imagine the urge like a wave in the ocean.
- Watch it rise... peak... and fall.

4. Stay With the Wave

- Urges come in waves. They will pass.
- Surf it, don't suppress it, don't give in to it.

You don't have to "win" against the urge. Just observe it without acting for a few minutes. Even one minute of awareness builds your ability to pause, reflect, and choose.

